

Module 9: Understanding Audit Roles and Responsibilities

Audit Team Leader / Lead Auditor

1. Primary Responsibility: Represents the certification body and manages the audit process. Recommends if the organization qualifies for certification.
2. Initial Contact and Coordination: Engages with the audit client to:
 - a. Confirm the audit process.
 - b. Discuss audit content.
 - c. Ensure the audit is feasible, considering risks and resource needs.
3. Audit Preparation:
 - d. Prepares audit documents.
 - e. Coordinates logistics for the audit team.
 - f. Develops the audit plan, assigning roles and determining the audit schedule.
4. Audit Execution:
 - g. Leads the opening meeting with the client.
 - h. Manages audit delivery and team.
 - i. Maintains a positive relationship with the auditee.
5. Evaluation and Reporting:
 - j. Analyzes findings to reach conclusions.
 - k. Conducts the closing meeting.
 - l. Prepares and distributes the audit report, and may approve or verify corrective actions.
6. Single vs. Larger Audits:
 - m. In single-auditor audits, that auditor handles all Lead Auditor responsibilities.
 - n. In larger audits, the Lead Auditor may also perform auditor tasks.

Role of Auditor

1. Data Collection and Analysis:
 - a. Analyzes and evaluates data collected during the audit.
 - b. Conducts site visits and interviews with auditees.
2. Verification and Documentation:
 - c. Verifies information received from auditees.
 - d. Documents audit findings and maintains appropriate records.
3. Remote Auditing: Uses remote auditing techniques if needed.
4. Meetings:
 - e. Attends opening and closing meetings.
 - f. Contributes to discussions on audit conclusions.
5. Audit Reporting: Assists in preparing the audit report.

6. Responsibility in Findings:

- a. Identifies potential findings, but the Lead Auditor decides their applicability and validity.

Role of Technical Specialists in Audits

1. Purpose and Expertise:

- b. Provide specific knowledge that auditors may lack, such as regulatory, legislative, or process-specific expertise.
- c. Examples include specialists for complex systems, chemistry, or legal and contract knowledge.

2. Support Roles:

- d. May assist with language, translation, and cultural context.
- e. Helps auditors understand local practices, cultural nuances, or specific industry requirements (e.g., union rights, social security).

3. Audit Findings:

- f. Can identify findings related to their expertise but must share these with the lead auditor for validation.

4. Integration into Audit:

- g. Lead auditor determines the best ways to use their expertise, including:
- h. Accompanying an auditor on a site visit.
- i. Participating in interviews (though not necessarily leading them).

Role of Certification Reviewer

1. Review and Verification:

- a. Reviews the Lead Auditor's recommendation and audit documents.
- b. Verifies that audit conclusions are accurate and all processes were correctly followed (e.g., correct audit days, auditor competencies).

2. Independence:

- c. Provides an independent decision on certification, with no prior contact with the client.

3. Competency Requirements:

- d. Must have the same competencies as a Lead Auditor, including knowledge of audit processes, the relevant standard, and the specific industry.

Role of Audit Client

1. Definition and Role:

- a. The organization requesting the audit, typically a senior manager or director, or someone overseeing the management system.

- b. Coordinates between the lead auditor and the organization.
- 2. Responsibilities Before and During the Audit:
 - c. Provides essential information for audit planning, including any factors that could impact audit risks (e.g., shutdowns, manager availability, health/safety issues).
 - d. Arranges and coordinates meetings, interviews, site visits, and resources (e.g., workspace, documentation) for the audit team.
 - e. Answers questions from management regarding audit scope, dates, and process.
- 3. Post-Audit Responsibilities:
 - f. Manages communication on corrections and corrective actions.
 - g. Reports and ensures closure of audit findings.

Role of Management Team in an Audit

- 1. Composition:
 - a. Includes senior leaders (e.g., CEO, directors, department heads) with responsibility over management systems.
 - b. In smaller organizations, may include most managers; in larger ones, only those directly involved with relevant systems.
- 2. Audit Participation:
 - c. Attends opening, closing, and daily debrief meetings as required.
 - d. Participates in interviews, providing accurate and honest information.
- 3. Support and Resources:
 - e. Communicates audit requirements to staff and facilitates their involvement.
 - f. Provides necessary resources, such as meeting rooms, interview time, and access for site visits.
 - g. Supplies audit evidence like documents and records as needed.
- 4. Post-Audit Actions:
 - h. Assists in preparing and implementing corrective actions for audit findings.
- 5. Authority and Coordination:
 - i. While the audit client manages logistics, the Management Team approves and supports these efforts.

Role of Auditees in an Audit

- 1. Definition:
 - a. Refers to anyone involved in the audit process, such as senior management, the audit client, supervisors, operators, and contractors.
- 2. Participation and Availability:

- b. Must be aware of the audit, make time to participate, and adjust schedules if needed.
- 3. Responsibilities:
 - c. Explain processes, provide documents and records, and guide auditors around the site if required.
 - d. Answer questions openly and honestly to help assess the management system's effectiveness.
- 4. Concerns and Auditor Approach:
 - e. Auditors, especially the Lead Auditor, should communicate respectfully to create a comfortable environment, addressing any concerns Auditees may have about potential findings.

Role of Hosts and Guides in an Audit

- 1. Primary Role:
 - f. Accompany the audit team and help gather requested audit evidence.
- 2. Guidelines for Interaction:
 - g. Avoid answering questions directed at management or staff, allowing auditors to assess the knowledge of the person being questioned.